

Friday — Run Sheet

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Everything you need for Friday, in one place, in order. Print this.

Before you walk in

The biggest risk Friday is that Joshua recites his document. He spent days writing sixteen pages of well-organized abstraction, and he'll naturally reach for those answers when asked anything. Abstraction is what we already have. Specifics are what we need.

So don't circulate an agenda, and don't open by discussing his document. Tell them it's a working session about how the firm actually operates day to day.

Record it, with everyone's permission. You can't run a good interview and take good notes at once, and the exact words people use are the raw material for the brand voice.

How to frame it when you sit down, something close to: *"I read your document twice and there's a lot in there. Today I want to do the opposite of it, though. It's all at thirty thousand feet and I need to get down on the ground, so I'm going to ask a lot of small, specific questions about actual clients and actual days."*

What to bring

- This run sheet, printed. Not a laptop.
- Your phone or a recorder, storage checked beforehand.
- The client-base spreadsheet, to hand over at the end.
- Nothing branded. No slides, no visual concepts, no name treatments.

The four habits

1. **Trade every abstraction for an example.** "We build trust" becomes "tell me about the last time a client trusted you with something they were embarrassed about." Every time, even when it feels repetitive.
2. **Let silence run.** Count to five after someone finishes. The first answer is rehearsed, the second is true, and the second only comes if you don't fill the gap.

3. **Ask "what happened next" a few times.** Most of the useful detail lives a few follow-ups past where people naturally stop.
4. **Write down exact phrasing.** When someone says something in plain regional language, stop and note it verbatim.

When Joshua starts quoting his own document, and he will: "Right, and I read that part. Give me the client that made you write it."

One thing to avoid. Don't debate the tagline, the name, or the niche during the open questions. Collect input, write it down, move on. If that debate starts at minute twenty it will eat the whole session, and none of you have the client data yet that would actually settle it.

The flow, at a glance

Order matters more than the clock does. Roughly, in this sequence:

1. **The business.** Confirm, don't ask cold: independent RIA in Waynesburg, bought by Joshua in December 2025, growth almost entirely referral-driven, average client in their 60s. Push: three to five years out? What would he never change?
2. **The numbers.** Confirm: ~\$135M AUM, 210+ households, ~40% growth over two years, working figures only. He was an employee before he bought it, push on whose referral relationships these actually are. Get real numbers on capacity, revenue target, hours per month.
3. **The clients.** Walk the household data together, before anyone talks about who to prioritize.
4. **How they arrive, what we do.** Still everyone in the room.
5. **Character exercise.** Write it down first, then go around.
6. **Tim and Hayley, by name.** Save the private question for one-on-one.
7. **Force the four decisions.** Owner and date each, before anyone leaves.
8. **Tim and Hayley go.** Founder interview, alone with Joshua, in the car.

If the afternoon gets away from you, protect two things above everything else: the household data, and how clients actually arrive. Everything else can happen by phone later.

How clients arrive, and what the firm does

How clients actually arrive

- Walk me through the last eight households that came on board. How did each one find you?
- How many of the 210 came with the firm when you bought it, and how many have you brought in yourself since December?
- Name the three people outside this firm who have sent you the most business. What is your actual relationship with each of them?
- When was the last time you asked someone for a referral, out loud, in those words?
- Who chose someone else in the last year? Do you know why, or are you guessing?
- When someone calls in for the first time, what do they literally say? Give me their actual words.
- Which accountants or attorneys do you already trust? Do you actually know if they send you business, or is that a guess?

What the firm actually does

- Walk me through the first ninety days with a new household. What actually happens, step by step?
- "Looking under every rock in the creek" is in your document. What was the last rock, and what was under it?
- Tell me about something you did for a client in the last month that took far more time than it was worth.
- Describe your best client meeting this year. Then describe the worst one.
- What did the previous owner do that you have already stopped doing? What have you deliberately kept?
- What do clients most often misunderstand about what you actually do?
- If you couldn't take someone on, who in this region would you send them to? Why that firm specifically?
- What is on the walls of the office right now?

The next generation

- How many of your clients' kids could actually name you?
- What happens to a client's money when they die? Does the next generation know who you are?

The character exercise

Everyone writes their own answer down before anyone says anything out loud, then go around and read them. Where the three of them disagree matters more than where they agree. Chase every answer with "why that?" Don't try to get through all of these, pick eight or so and follow whichever one opens up.

Who the firm is

- If you had to put one well-known person across the table from your clients, someone they'd trust immediately, who is it? Why them?
- Now the opposite. Who would be completely wrong for this firm, even though they're successful and people like them?
- Name a business, anywhere, any industry, that treats people the way you want to treat people.
- Name a business you'd hate to be mistaken for.

What it's made of

- If the firm were a vehicle, what is it? Be specific, down to the year if you can.
- If you gave every new client one physical object on the day they signed on, what would it be?
- What's in this firm's toolbox that other firms don't carry?
- Does this firm write a typed letter or a handwritten one?

Forced choices (make them pick one, no hedging)

- Would you rather lose a client to a bigger firm or to a cheaper one?
- Would you rather be the firm people recommend, or the firm people search for?
- Sharp, or steady?
- The firm that knows the most, or the firm that asks the best questions?
- If you could only be known for one thing in this region, what is it?

Waynesburg

- What's the most Waynesburg thing about this firm?
- Who from around here, living or dead, would you want a picture of on the office wall?
- If the firm moved to Pittsburgh tomorrow, what would it lose?

Questions for Tim and Hayley

Ask them directly, by name. With the owner in the room, staff default to nodding, and putting a specific question to a specific person is the only way around that.

- When a client calls in, what do they usually want? What is the most common reason the phone rings?
- What do clients say about Joshua when he isn't standing there?
- Which clients do you personally look forward to seeing come through the door?
- What part of how we work do you think we are genuinely good at? What part frustrates you?
- When someone at a cookout asks what you do for a living, what do you actually say?
- What has changed around here since December, from where you sit?

Hold this one for a private moment, not the group: "What does Joshua believe about this firm that you're not sure is still true?" Nobody answers that honestly in front of the owner.

The four decisions to force

You don't need all four fully resolved Friday, but leave with a named owner and a date for each.

- **Suffix.** Financial, Wealth Management, or Asset Management. (Spelling is already settled: Casteel.)
- **January 1.** Confirmed: a simple landing page, LinkedIn, and stationery live that day, full site continuing into Q1. Get Joshua's buy-in specifically on budget and capacity, since if scope creeps past "simple," this date is what breaks.
- **Service tiers.** Joshua hands over the document he held back.
- **Client-base analysis.** Joshua commits to a date for the data export, ideally two weeks out.

On the name. Push for the spelling at minimum, even if the suffix stays open. My recommendation is Casteel. Also ask who else gets a vote, a spouse or partner's opinion is better heard now than in November.

On the date. You've decided January 1 holds, and that only works if "simple" stays simple. Get Joshua's buy-in specifically on budget and capacity, since if scope creeps past simple, this date is the first thing that breaks.

On compliance. Find out who handles it, Joshua says it's an outside firm rather than a person. Form ADV Part 1 Item 1.C and Form CRS both need amending promptly once the name change is legally effective, not at the annual update. There may be a transition window where client materials carry both names.

On tiers. Joshua flagged that he wanted to hand the service-tier strategy over separately. Friday is the moment to ask for it. The website can't lead with a flagship offering we haven't been shown.

Budget and capacity, ask out loud

These are the ones where the first answer and the real answer are different, you only get the second one by sitting in the pause.

- How many new households a year do you actually want?
- At what point does taking on more start to hurt the work?
- What is the revenue number you're aiming at, and by when?
- Beyond my fee, what are you willing to spend on photography, printing, and hosting?
- How many hours a month will you personally give to this?
- Are you willing to be written about, photographed, and on video?
- Who besides you gets a vote on the name?

Don't accept a vague answer, especially on budget and capacity. If he says "whatever it takes," ask for a number, then ask what number would make him wince.

One I'll handle myself: what compliance actually permits around client stories and testimonials, and whether Joshua can post without pre-approval. Get the compliance contact directly rather than relaying it through him.

The founder interview

Save this for the end, alone with Joshua, once Tim and Hayley have gone. Do it in the car, driving Castile Run Road. Bring a camera, you'll want to scout photography while you're out there. Ask everything anyway, even what you already know, and let him tell it long.

Where the name came from

- Where exactly is the house on Castile Run Road? What is still standing?
- How do you know it was spelled with two E's? Where did you see that?
- When did it change, and who changed it?

- What does that road mean to you that it wouldn't mean to a stranger?

The family

- Your document mentions ironworking, coal, and the early gas industry. Who specifically? Which generation, which mine, which mill?
- Tell me about your grandfather. What did he do, and what was he like about money?
- What is the family story that gets told at every holiday?
- What did your parents believe about money, and what did they get right?

Why this firm

- What was your role at the firm before you bought it, and how long were you there?
- Why buy the firm you were already working at, instead of starting your own or going somewhere else?
- What did you almost do instead? What scared you about it at the time?
- What did you find when you got inside that you did not expect?
- Who was Milinovich? What did he care about, and is he still around?
- What are you keeping from him, and what are you quietly undoing?

What he actually believes

- What is your first memory of money?
- What do you believe about this work that most advisors would disagree with?
- Have you ever told someone not to hire you? What happened?
- Why does changing the name matter to you personally? What would be lost if you just kept Milinovich & Co.?
- Ten years from now, what has to be true for this to have been worth it?

After Friday

Send me the recording or your notes, whichever you have, don't clean them up. Verbatim phrasing is more useful than a tidy summary.

Four specific things, beyond that:

- The eight most recent households and how each one found the firm
- The literal opening words people use when they call in
- Joshua's honest competitive set, in his own reasoning
- Photos of the office, including the walls

Open questions I still have:

- Who are Tim and Hayley, and what do they do? It changes which questions land.
- Does Joshua own the firm outright, or are there partners or an outside stake?
- Is there an existing client-relationship system, and does it hold the data the spreadsheet asks for?
- Has anyone secured the domains yet, for both spellings?